

ray of HOPE

✱ Jan Swasthya Sahayog

Project Providing healthcare at minimal cost

Can-do Icon The inspiration for the path-finding health network stems from the good old-fashioned values

The health-care centre at Ganiyari village provides consultations to over 1.05 lakh patients from 1,500 villages in the district and beyond

WONDER DOCTOR:
Kataria with his patients

In this overgrowth of dense forests lies a piece of impoverished sub-Saharan Africa, right in the heart of a gleaming, chrome-encrusted nation. In an island of nothingness, in a sea of plenty, Third World diseases, virtually banished from private healthcare behemoths, cast a long and deadly shadow. But in this, there was a ray of hope when

a group of 10 doctors, in their mid-30s, left the metropolitan comforts of Delhi and came to Bilaspur in Chhattisgarh in 2000. What followed was a public healthcare network, Jan Swasthya Sahayog, that has gradually come to cover about 1,500 villages of the district. At the apex of this efficient healthcare programme is a hospital in Ganiyari village with a well-organised Outpatients' Department (OPD) that charges the patients a pittance of Rs 2.

One of the founder-members of the non-profit organisation, Dr Yogesh Jain, 44, is a dedicated being. Even after a long and tiring session at the hospital, he has no second thoughts talking about his decision

to relocate his professional base. "At AIIMS 10 doctors can replace me. Here, nobody would. That's why we need a long-term commitment," he says. The Jan Swasthya Sahayog boasts of 10 post-graduate doctors from some of the leading institutes of the country, like AIIMS and CMC, Vellore. Their common cause is to remove inequity prevailing in the health sector.

On any given day, the hospital sees 250 OPD patients. It has a radiology department and a laboratory to run all kinds of tests including sputum culture for testing tuberculosis. "The idea is to have a pin-pointed accuracy in diagnosis as it reduces time and expenses," says Dr Raman Kataria, one of the only three paediatric surgeons in the entire state. Kataria, 44, treated a remarkable case a few months back. Shravan Kumar, all of 18 months, who belonged to a Scheduled Caste family was seriously underweight because of an obstruction in his large intestine. Shravan's parents and well as elder sister, who were suffering from tuberculosis, were also treated simultaneously. "These cases are an eye-opener to the challenges that lie ahead," says Kataria.

As a part of its community outreach programme, the organisation runs a network of 100 community volunteers to diagnose and administer drugs for diseases like malaria and pneumonia. The network also includes neo-literate women who help with pregnancy cases. Cost-effectiveness is the key to success. The recurring cost and establishment expenses are met by a variety of donor agencies including AIIMS, the Department of Science and Technology and a few fellow doctors who have made a big not only in India but overseas too. And as it expands further, this medicine without borders hopes to encompass the growing community.

by Ambresh Mishra



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DR YOGESH JAIN, Co-founder, Jan Swasthya Sahayog

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